Reference: HXC 14 November 2025

Short Form Report [DRAFT 1]

1, Riverside Cottages, The Dean, Alresford, SO24 9BE



Home & Commercial

Surveyor: Adam Clutterbuck

Date of site visit: 02 September 2025

1. Introduction

Surveyor	Adam Clutterbuck
Contact number	07904093727
Date of Instruction	01 September 2025
Date of site visit	02 September 2025
Date of report issue	15 November 2025

	Mr N and Mrs L Scarr
Property address	1 Riverside Cottages The Dean Alresford SO24 9BE
Reference	HXC
Date of Claim	05 March 2025
Date of Loss	28 January 2025
Type of Loss	Flooding of ground floor layers and base of walls with sewage water due to failure of Southern Water pumping station located on higher ground adjacent to the rear garden.

2. Background

2.1 Property Description

2.1.1 The property is a Victorian end-of terrace cottage constructed of solid brick walls under a slate roof. The property was extensively altered and extended in or around 2018 including the installation of a lining of thermal blockwork to the exterior walls.

2.1.2 The flank wall to the left-hand side (when viewed from the road) is earth-retaining to a height of around one metre where it abuts the sloping road to the Southern Water Sewage pumping station.

2.1.3 The right-hand wall to the rear addition (Kitchen/Dining area) is also earth-retaining to a height or around one metre.

2.1.4 The floor structure is made up of concrete slab poured in sections.

2.2 Description of Incident to Date

2.2.1 My understanding is that on or around 28 February 2025 there was a catastrophic failure with the equipment within the Southern Water pumping station located in a yard adjacent to the rear garden of 1 Riverside Cottages (the 'Property').

2.2.2 The topography is such that the pumping station is uphill from the house, with the land sloping towards the rear garden and rear elevation of the Property.

2.2.3 The tarmac road to the pumping station slopes uphill from the road (The Dean) and when this passes the end flank wall of the Property.

2.2.4 It is understood that sewage water surcharged as a result from the main sewer pipes leading to/from the pumping station and flooded the ground in the vicinity between the pumping station and the Property.

2.2.5 The level of flooding within the property is reported to be around 100mm (four inches).

2.2.6 The floodwater and increased groundwater levels resulted in internal flooding of the property with wastewater.

2.2.7 A Pest control company were appointed to deal with an infestation of rats attracted by the sewage that is reported to have affected the Property and the adjoining two properties in the terrace.

2.2.8 Whilst it is reported that there is a non-return valve ('NRV') fitted to the outflow drainage pipe from the Property (fitted circa 2000) it is understood that this did not prevent sewage water from travelling through and over the ground resulting in external flooding at the rear of the property.

2.2.9 The pest control company is reported to have identified that the NRV could not have operated as it the manhole chamber at the side terrace of the house was found to be silted up.

2.2.10 I have attached three appendices to assist with my reporting and avoid unnecessary replication.

2.2.11 Appendix 1 is a copy of the layout plans and elevation for the property as submitted for planning approval in 2018.

2.2.12 Appendix 2 is a map showing the geology of the immediate area where the Property is located.

2.2.13 Appendix 3 is a copy of a 'Position Paper' drafted by Mr Scarr summarising key aspects of the claim.

3. Observations

3.1 External

3.1.1 Front exterior

3.1.1.1 The front garden is higher than the internal ground floor levels with two steps down to the front entrance door. The brick courses at the base of the front elevation wall have a vertical damp barrier installed to prevent lateral penetration of moisture from the garden level. The front garden area is covered with stones/aggregate to allow rainfall to drain into the subsoil.



Photo 1 - View of front garden and entrance down 2 steps



Photo 2 - View of entrance from front gate



Photo 3 - Area outside of entrance that flooded at the time of the incident



Photo 4 - Vertical damp proofing to lower front brickwork wall



Photo 5 - Two steps down from front garden level



Photo 6 - Damp proof barrier with gravel along front elevation wall



Photo 7 - Vertical slates installed between stones and vertical damp barrier

3.1.2 Rear Exterior

3.1.2.1 The rear garden is laid to grass and slopes down towards the house. The pumping station is with a yard adjacent to the large panelled rear gates at the top end of the garden.A terrace area with stone paving slabs is across the rear of the house with the paving at or around level with the internal concrete slab. After the incident a temporary sump was installed by contractors at the rear of the terrace to enable flood water to be pumped away.The ground levels on either side of the house are at around one metre above the internal finished floor level (apart from the original party wall of the Lounge).It is understood that Southern Water had previously installed a non-return valve within the drainage under the terrace at the side of the house to prevent a possible surcharge from the main sewer.



Photo 8 - Rear terrace and relationship to internal floor slab level



Photo 9 - High boundary wall is earth retaining against drive to pumping station



Photo 10 - Terrace is lower than rear garden



Photo 11 - Sump created by contractors to allow a pump to remove floor water

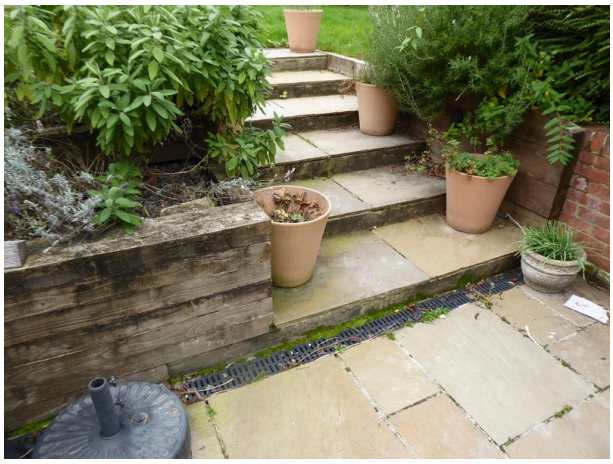


Photo 12 - Steps up to higher rear garden



Photo 13 - Rear elevation



Photo 14 - View from rear garden



Photo 15 - Rear garden with large wooden panel gates leading out to location of pumping station



Photo 16 - High ground level (with stones) to side of house (LH side when viewed from rear)



Photo 17 - Relationship of rear terrace and internal floor slab level at threshold

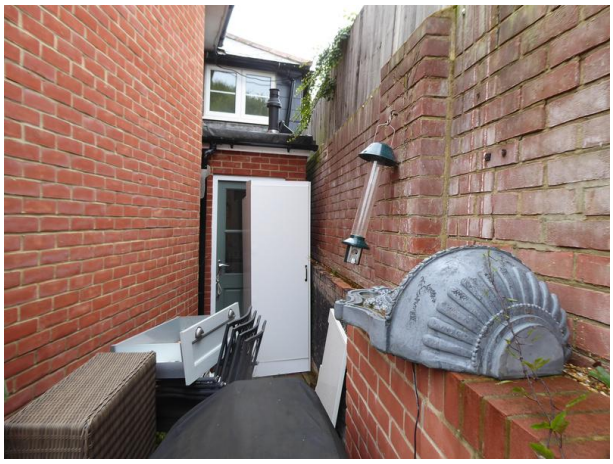


Photo 18 - RH side of house when viewed from rear



Photo 19 - Earth retaining boundary wall (black). The manhole in the foreground is understood to house a non-return valve to prevent a surcharge from the sewer.

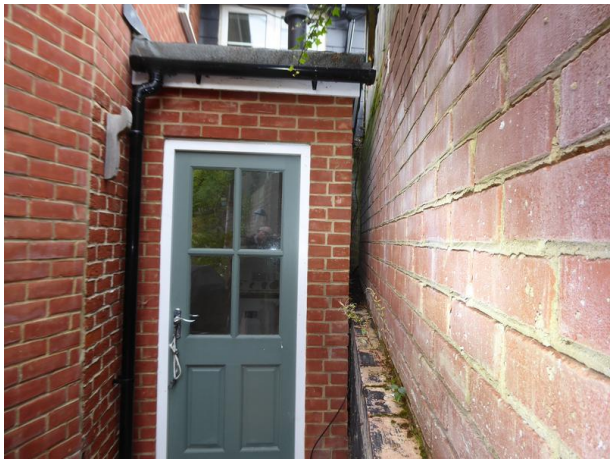


Photo 20 - House adjoining boundary

3.1.3 Wastewater pumping station

3.1.3.1 The ground to the left-hand end elevation of the house is higher than the internal floor level and slopes upwards with the slope of the road to garages and the Southern Water pumping station. The yard of the pumping station is adjacent to the large wooden panelled gates to the rear garden of the Property. There were redundant pumps located in the yard including one understood to have been removed at the time of the incident with details indicating that it was installed in 2002 and presumed to be beyond repair. A roadside gully in the carriageway at the foot of the road to the pumping station was full of silt with live vegetation growing at the time of my inspection in August 2025.



Photo 21 - Sloping drive up to pumping station next to cottage



Photo 22 - Sloping drive with gates to pumping station at end; ground is higher than floor of house to side elevation of cottage



Photo 23 - Gates of pumping station and yard



Photo 24 - Sign 1 (of 2) on gates



Photo 25 - Sign 2 (of 2) on gates



Photo 26 - Close proximity of pumping station yard to rear garden gates of Cottage. The tarmac road surface slopes towards the drop-kerb entrance to the gates and rear



Photo 27 - View of tarmac road from pumping station alongside boundary of Cottage, sloping down to the road (The Dean)



Photo 28 - Junction of drive and road with road gully grating at side of carriageway



Photo 29 - Gully was full of silt and live vegetation growing at time of inspection (02/08/25)



Photo 30 - Spare pump body in pumping station yard



Photo 31 - Removed (defective?) pump in pumping station yard



Photo 32 - High sloping road with cast-iron manhole cover and ground level at side of house (1m+ above internal floor slab level)



Photo 33 - Pump removed at the time of the incident



Photo 34 - Part of the pump removed



Photo 35 - The pump removed is understood to date back to 2002 and presumed to be beyond repair as it was left on the yard floor in pieces.

3.1.4 Images prior to flooding

3.1.4.1 These images show the exterior prior to the flooding incident.



Photo 94 - Front elevation and garden



Photo 95 - View from rear garden



Photo 96 - View from rear garden



Photo 97 - View from rear garden



Photo 98 - Rear elevation and RH side viewed from garden

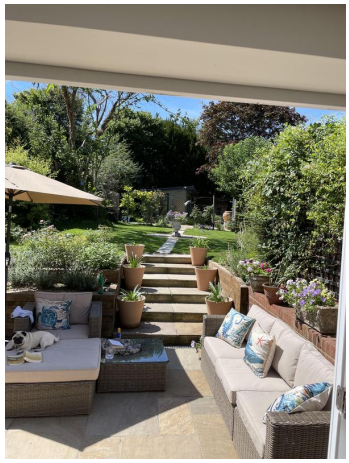


Photo 99 - Steps to raised rear garden viewed from rear through open glazed doors

3.2 Internal

3.2.1 Entrance Foyer

3.2.1.1 The entrance hall floor slab level is below the external ground level, with steps down from the front garden to the entrance threshold. The external ground level to the end flank wall is around 1m higher than the internal slab level. The wall plaster had been removed from the thermal blockwork walls that form an inner leaf to the original walls and form the internal room dividing walls.The staircase is at the back of the hall and there was visible damp to the wall/slab junction to all sides of the hall.A temporary sump had been formed within the slab in the corner next to the front entrance.



Photo 36 - Wall plaster stripped to expose thermal blockwork skin



Photo 37 - View from front entrance



Photo 38 - Front entrance - exposed slab below outside ground levels



Photo 39 - Step at threshold



Photo 40 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction



Photo 41 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction



Photo 42 - Sump formed in corner to allow temporary pump installation



Photo 43 - Plaster removed to 1.2m above screed level against earth retaining wall



Photo 44 - Height of external ground - 1m above internal slab level



Photo 45 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction



Photo 46 - Visible damp at base of staircase string



Photo 47 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction beneath staircase

3.2.2 Lounge

3.2.2.1 The Longe is the main room across the front of the house; there was a log burner located on an elevated hearth within the fireplace. All walls had the plaster removed to around 1.2m high to expose the original brickwork and more recently installed blockwork. Visible damp was evident at the wall/floor junction around the perimeter of the concrete floor slab.



Photo 48 - View of fireplace



Photo 49 - Opening to Kitchen/Dining area



Photo 50 - View back to Entrance Foyer



Photo 51 - View to Entrance Foyer and opening to Kitchen/ Dining area



Photo 52 - View from Entrance Foyer

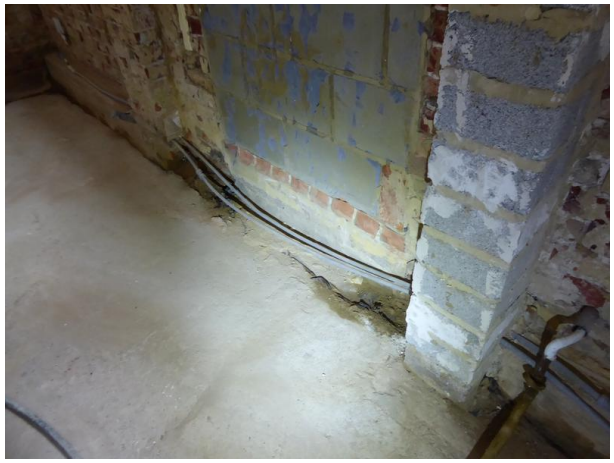


Photo 53 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction



Photo 54 - Visible damp at base of party wall



Photo 55 - Visible damp to lower brickwork courses of party wall and to slab junction



Photo 56 - Visible damp along front wall/slab junction



Photo 57 - Visible damp along front wall/slab junction



Photo 58 - Visible damp at join in slab

3.2.3 Kitchen/Dining

3.2.3.1 The concrete floor slab sections are all the same level now that the affected floor layers have been removed.There was a one-step up from the lounge to the rear room originally; therefore, this indicates that the Kitchen/Dining/WC/Utility floors were perhaps raised to accommodate insulation.All plaster and plasterboard linings had been removed to around 1.2m high.There was visible moisture at all joints within the slab and all wall/floor junctions. The external ground level to the side wall on the RH side (facing the rear garden) was around 1m higher than the internal slab level. Polyethylene sheeting was evident at the edges of the floor slabs, and along the interface with the threshold of the rear glazed unit with double doors and sidelights. There were service pipes, cables, socket boxes, and a painted steel post exposed where the linings and floor layers had been removed.



Photo 59 - View towards rear



Photo 60 - Kitchen/Dining area with joint across floor slab



Photo 61 - View towards WC/Utility



Photo 62 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction



Photo 63 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction



Photo 64 - Visible damp at joint in slab



Photo 65 - Interface of slab sections and wall with steel post



Photo 66 - Base of post and blockwork wall



Photo 67 - Black polyethylene evident at joint between slab and glazed door threshold



Photo 68 - Slab is at similar level to external paving to rear terrace



Photo 69 - Horizontal water mark along base of earth retaining wall



Photo 70 - Visible damp at wall/slab junction



Photo 71 - View into Lounge area from Kitchen/Diner



Photo 72 - Hand indicates height of ground on outside of wall



Photo 73 - Wall exposed to 1.2m above screed level



Photo 74 - Height of external ground is 1m above slab level

3.2.4 WC/Utility area

3.2.4.1 Most (but not all) of the plaster in this area had been removed to 1.2m high exposing plumbing services and drainage pipes. The boiler was still in position on the dividing wall. Where the floor layers had been removed, visible moisture was evident at the joints between slab sections and around the perimeters at the wall/floor junction. A patch of new concrete appeared to have been laid in the Utility area.



Photo 75 - View of utility area with boiler on wall



Photo 76 - View of WC and Utility area from Dining area



Photo 77 - Plumbing and visible moisture to slab joints and edges.



Photo 78 - Exposed detailing of joints and edges of slab sections



Photo 79 - Drainage pipework



Photo 80 - Floor areas between WC and Utility



Photo 81 - Unfinished section in corner of Utility



Photo 82 - Utility with wall plaster removed from blockwork inner leaf to around 1.2m high



Photo 83 - Junction between Kitchen and Utility where wall removed



Photo 84 - Brick cavity wall, 3 courses high, below DPC of rear entrance door in Utility.

3.2.5 Images prior to strip out

3.2.5.1 The images below were provided to me and understood to show the internal rooms prior to the strip out works.

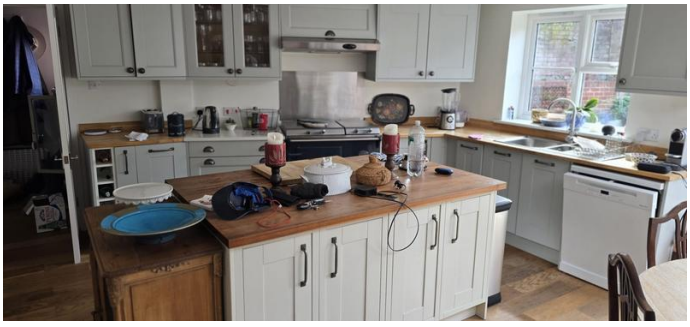


Photo 85 - Kitchen area with Utility in the background

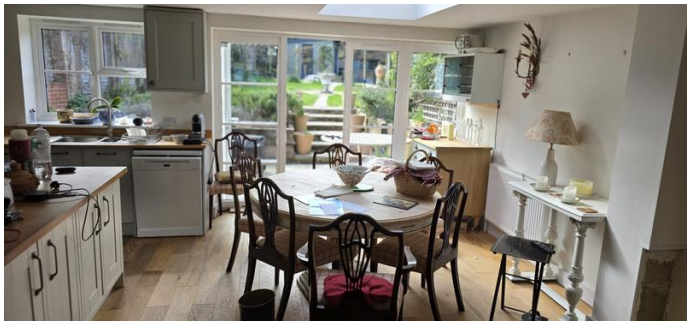


Photo 86 - Dining area looking towards the rear



Photo 87 - Step up from Lounge to Dining area



Photo 88 - Front wall of Lounge with radiator



Photo 89 - Lounge fireplace



Photo 90 - Entrance Hall



Photo 91 - Engineered oak flooring

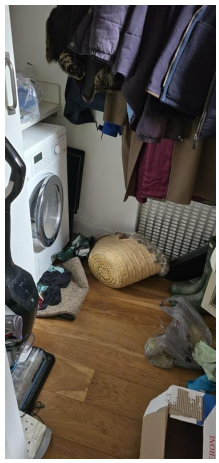


Photo 92 - Utility floor



Photo 93

3.2.6 Images prior to flooding

3.2.6.1 Interior views of main rooms prior to flooding incident



Photo 100 - Entrance Hall

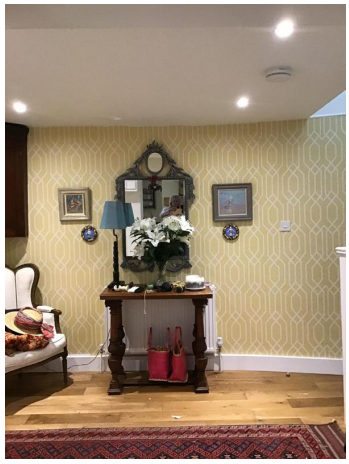


Photo 101 - Entrance Hall



Photo 102 - Staircase in Entrance Hall

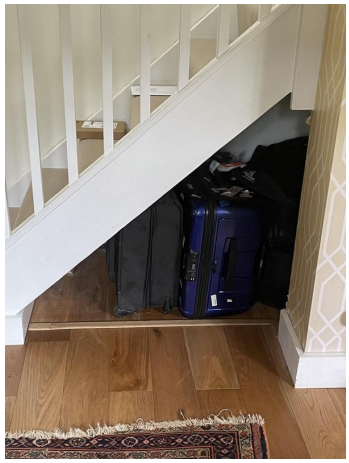


Photo 103 - Area below staircase



Photo 104 - Kitchen area with doors to WC and Utility in the background



Photo 105 - Island unit in Kitchen area



Photo 106 - Corner of Lounge area



Photo 107 - Dining area



Photo 108 - Lounge area



Photo 109 - Step up to Dining area from Lounge



Photo 110 - View from Lounge into Dining area

3.2.7 Images recorded w/c 09 June 2015 of strip out works

3.2.7.1 Images provided to me were recorded during w/c 09 June 2025 showing wet screed after flooring removed and wet base of walls after wall plaster and lining removed to 1.2m high.



Photo 111 - Disconnected cooker and central island unit



Photo 112 - Wet screed adjacent to rear glazed doors

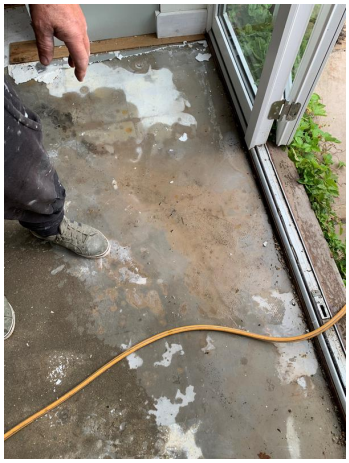


Photo 113 - Wet screed

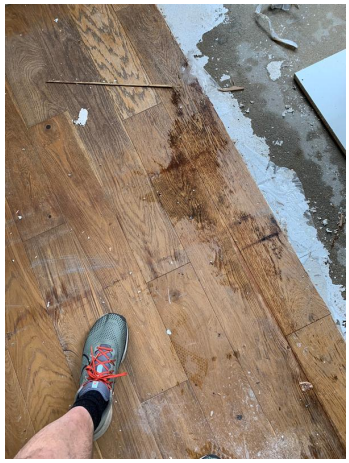


Photo 114 - Engineered oak flooring



Photo 115 - Plaster to kitchen area removed to 1.2m



Photo 116 - T&G end section of flooring plank

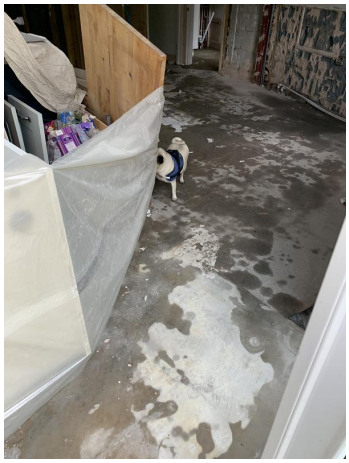


Photo 117 - Wet screed in Kitchen area

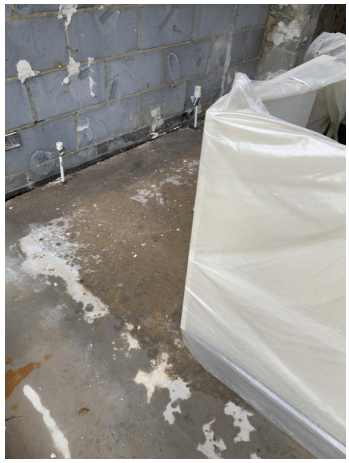


Photo 118 - Wet screed and base of wall



Photo 119 - Wet screed and base of wall



Photo 120 - Wet screed and base of wall



Photo 121 - Damp screed to Living Room



Photo 122 - Damp screed in Living Room by fireplace



Photo 123 - Wet screed



Photo 124 - Wet screed in WC area



Photo 125 - Wet screed where kitchen units and cooker removed

3.2.8 Images recorded of strip out works -28 July 2025

3.2.8.1 When the flooring layers (including screed and insulation board) the concrete floor slab surfaces were found to be wet. There was polyethylene sheeting evident protruding from the edges of the concrete slab sections.



Photo 126 - Wet slab exposed in Dining area

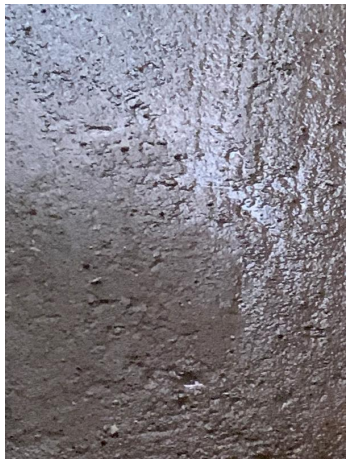


Photo 127 - Wet slab surface

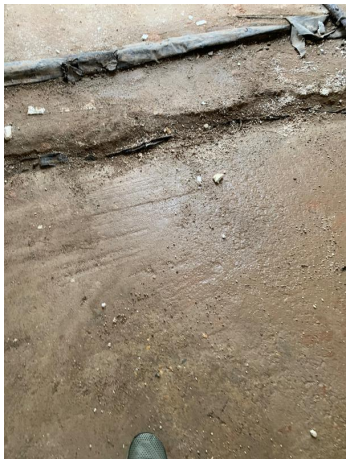


Photo 128 - Black polyethylene evident at joint between slab and screed in Kitchen/Dining area

4. Discussion

4.1 At the time of my appointment of 01 September 2025, and first visit of 02 September 2025, the property had been stripped out to remove all contents at ground floor ('GF') level, with wall plaster and linings removed to 1.2m above floor level, and the floor layers removed to expose the GF concrete slab sections.

4.2 It is understood that drying contractors Bio Response had attended and undertaken an initial clean within a week of the incident occurring.

4.3 Bio Response then installed drying equipment after strip out works during w/c 09 June 2015; however, I have not seen any of their reports to date.

4.4 I have been provided with details of proposals and quotations from Maclennan Waterproofing specialists.

4.5 I have also been made aware of the opinions of medical experts with regards to the health of Mrs Scarr and her diagnosis of an impaired immune system with the potential health risks from any residual damp, mould or sewage-related contamination.

4.6 A Pest control company are understood to have been appointed to deal with an infestation of rats attracted by the sewage that is reported to have affected the Property and the two adjoining properties in the terrace.

4.7 Whilst it is reported that there is a non-return valve ('NRV') fitted to the outflow drainage pipe from the Property (fitted circa 2000) it is understood that this did not prevent sewage water from travelling through and over the ground resulting in external flooding at the rear of the property.

4.8 The pest control company is reported to have identified that the NRV could not have operated as it the manhole chamber at the side terrace of the house was found to be silted up.

4.9 I have attached three appendices to assist with my reporting and avoid unnecessary replication.

4.10 Appendix 1 is a copy of the layout plans and elevation for the property as submitted for planning approval in 2018. I have used the room names in my report for ease of reference.

4.11 Appendix 2 is a map showing the geology of the immediate area where the Property is located.

4.12 Appendix 3 is a copy of a 'Position Paper' drafted by Mr Scarr summarising key aspects of the claim.

4.13 On plan, the Property scales as being 25m from the banks of the River Alre. The river is a tributary of the River Itchen and a classic chalk stream with shallow gravel bed and fast flowing waters, fed by chalk springs.

4.14 Whilst the surrounding geology is of chalk, The Dean is situated on a hill that runs downhill from West Street (itself a fairly steep hill) on a clay subsoil, with some silt, sand, and gravel.

4.15 As shown on the coloured plan in Appendix 2, unlike the surrounding chalk formation, the clay will restrict/ prevent any flood water from draining downwards and will allow 'perched' water flooding to occur above the clay layers.

4.16 From my understanding of the incident, foul water (containing sewage) from the pumping station ran over and into the ground towards the Property.

4.17 From the evidence provided to me in the form of images, and from my own inspections, it is evident that water ingress occured due to the incident, resulting in damage and contamination to the floor layers and lower parts of all walls within the Property.

4.18 Fixtures and fittings, flooring, and contents items that were within the property, and external furniture and items from the rear terrace had been removed at the time of my visits.

4.19 As the structure of the property is partially below the external ground levels (on either side of the Property), there must be measures in place to prevent moisture penetration to the retaining walls. These are lined with thermal blockwork and therefore it is considered likely that there is some form of vertical barrier protection in place behind the blockwork leaf constructed inside. This would be classed as a Type A (barrier) protection according to BS 8102, the British Standard code of Practice as referred to in the relevant section of the Building Regulations (Approved Document C - 'ADC') at the time of installation.

4.20 There is no sign of water penetration through the walls; however, visible moisture was evident at the wall/floor slab junctions where the floor construction layers had been stripped out due to water damage.

4.21 Here it was evident that polyethylene membranes had been installed to prevent ingress from moisture from the ground (both water and vapour); however, it is not clear how the sections of membrane were linked to form a continuous barrier to moisture.

4.22 As the existing waterproofing measures have been unavoidably disturbed, and partially removed, by the necessary strip out works, it will be necessary to install a new system.

4.23 Given the circumstances I do not consider it possible or economically viable to simply repair the original waterproofing installation as this would involve the removal of the inner leak of blockwork walls and in addition, no details are known as to precisely what has been installed.

4.24 The initial submissions from Maclennan waterproofing included the application of a cementius waterproof slurry followed by a cavity drainage membrane ('CDM') system.

4.25 Due to the risk of health to occupants in this situation, especially Mrs Scarr, it is my view that a sealed CDM system would be appropriate to install (as intended for situations where there is contaminated ground or risk of radon to occupants).

4.26 Maclennan provided revised proposals dated 04 November 2025 as my Appendix 4.

4.27 There will be quite extensive works to be undertaken by a general contractor to accomodate the needs of Maclennan before, during, and after installation of their system.

4.28 The same will apply if an alternative waterproofing specialist was to undertake the waterproofing works.

5. Conclusions

5.1 It is evident that foul water flooding occurred and the source was the pumping station behind the Property.

5.2 The drainage for the Property (both foul water and surface water) should be subject to a CCTV survey to identify any blockages due to residue and/or silt from the incident, any defects, and to ensure the NRV is operating as it should to prevent future flooding issues.

5.3 Flood barriers (planks) to door openings and any air bricks at low level should be obtained and installed when there are storms forecast and/or the Property is vacant for any extended period of time.

5.4 The installation of an external pump to prevent surface water flooding of the rear terrace should be considered.

5.5 The property has been stripped out and subject to preparation works, a new waterproofing system can be installed that is also compliant to provide protection against gas or other contamination from the ground and affected structures.

5.6 With regards to waterproofing works, my advice is to ensure that whoever undertakes the installation of a system, they should have suitable and adequate insurance cover for both the design and the installation of their system. In this way any guarantee offered will be as worthwhile as is possible within this specialist field. I believe Maclennan have such cover, but this should be verified in writing beforehand if they are to be appointed.

5.7 In my view, the proposals from Maclennan should meet the requirements of ADC (Building Regulations) and BS 8102 as referred to in the relevant sections of ADC.

5.8 In addition to reinstallation of an appropriate waterproofing/gas resistant system, I recommend that the local authority be contacted to ensure the road gully outside the Property is cleared and kept maintained to reduce/ prevent surface water flooding outside the Property.

5.9 The vegetation at the side of the road adjoining the end flank wall of the house should be removed to allow access and maintenance of the verge to keep in good order.

End of Report

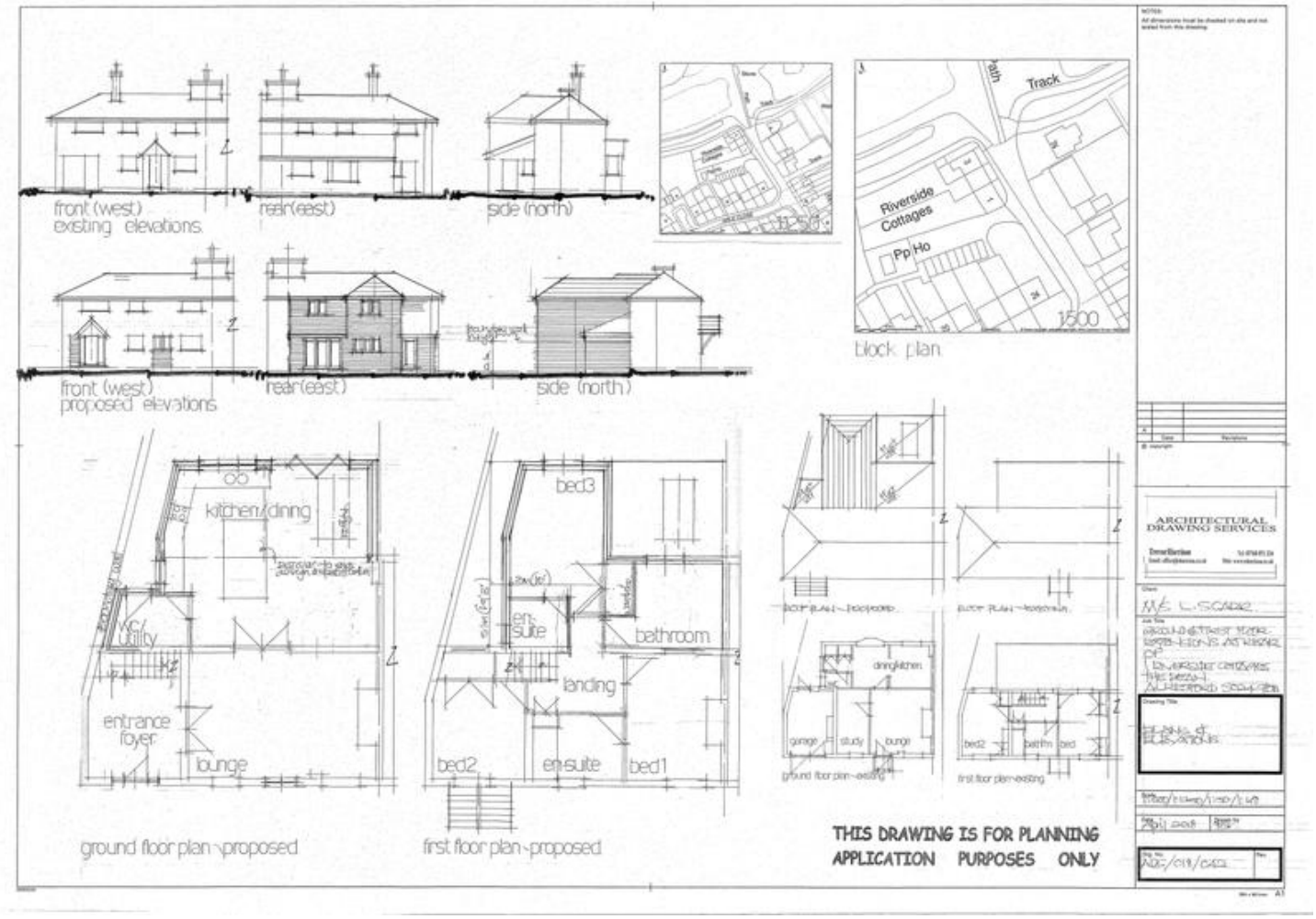
Please note that this is intentionally a short report to summarise the situation; however if further and more detailed information is required please let us know.

The content of this report is for the benefit of the instructing client only and should not be relied upon by third parties as no liability is accepted.

Appendix

- Appendix 1 Appendix 1 - PLANS_AND_ELEVATIONS-2018
- Appendix 2 Appendix 2 - Geology of The Dean
- Appendix 3 Appendix 3 - Position Paper Waterproofing - 1 Riverside Cottages The Dean Alresford SO24 9BE
- Appendix 4 Appendix 4 - Maclennan waterproofing and gas resistance proposals of 04-11-2025

Appendix 1 Appendix 1 - PLANS_AND_ELEVATIONS-2018



Appendix 2 Appendix 2 - Geology of The Dean

Appendix 3 Appendix 3 - Position Paper Waterproofing - 1 Riverside Cottages The Dean Alresford SO24 9BE

Appendix 4 Appendix 4 - Maclennan waterproofing and gas resistance proposals of 04-11-2025